ANNEX
GUIDELINES FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF SHIPBOARD
OIL POLLUTION EMERGENCY PLANS
RESOLUTION MEPC.54(32)
adopted on 6 March 1992
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These Guidelines, prepared by the Marine Environment Protection Committee of the International Maritime Organization (IMO), contain information for the preparation of shipboard oil pollution emergency plans. These plans are required under regulation 26 of Annex I of the International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, 1973, as modified by the Protocol of 1978 relating thereto, as amended (MARPOL 73/78).

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required under regulation 26 of Annex I of the International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, 1973, as modified by the Protocol of 1978 relating thereto, as amended (MARPOL 73/78).
The main objectives of these Guidelines are:
to assist ship owners in preparing shipboard oil pollution emergency plans that comply with the cited regulation;
to assist Governments in developing and enacting domestic laws which give force to and implement the cited regulation.
In the interest of uniformity, Governments are requested to refer to these Guidelines when preparing appropriate national regulations.
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Pollution Emergency Plans
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GUIDELINES FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF SHIPBOARD
OIL POLLUTION EMERGENCY PLANS
1.1 These Guidelines have been developed to assist with the preparation of the shipboard oil pollution emergency plans (hereafter referred to as the "Plan(s)") that are required by regulation 26 of Annex I of the International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships, 1973, as modified by the Protocol of 1978 relating thereto, as amended (MARPOL 73/78) (hereafter referred to as the "Convention"). The Plan must be approved in accordance with this regulation.
1.2 The Guidelines are comprised of three primary sections:
.1 Introduction: This section provides a general overview of the subject-matter and introduces the reader to the basic concept of the Guidelines and the Plans that are expected to be developed from them .
. 2 Mandatory provisions: This section provides guidance to ensure that

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subject-matter and introduces the reader to the basic concept of the Guidelines and the Plans that are expected to be developed from them .
. 2 Mandatory provisions: This section provides guidance to ensure that the mandatory provisions of regulation 26 of Annex I of the Convention are met .
3 Non-Mandatory provisions: This section provides guidance concerning the inclusion of other information in the Plan. This information, although not required by regulation 26 of Annex I of MARPOL 73/78, may be required by local authorities in ports visited by the ship, or it may be added to provide additional assistance to the ship's master when responding to an emergency situation. This section also provides guidance on updating and exercising of the Plan.
1.3 Concept of Guidelines: These guidelines are intended to provide a starting point for the preparation of the Plans for specific ships. The broad spectrum of ships for which Plans are required makes it impractical to provide specific guidelines for each ship type. Plan writers are cautioned that they must consider in their Plans the many variables that apply to their ships.

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spectrum of ships for which Plans are required makes it impractical to provide specific guidelines for each ship type. Plan writers are cautioned that they must consider in their Plans the many variables that apply to their ships. Some of these variables include: type and size of ship, cargo, route, and

shore based management structure. The guidelines are not intended to be a compilation of menu items from which the Plan writer can select certain sections and produce a workable Plan. For a Plan to be effective and to comply with regulation 26 of Annex I of the Convention, it must be carefully tailored to the particular ship for which it is intended. Properly used, the guidelines will ensure that all appropriate issues are considered in developing the Plan.
1.4 Concept of the Plan: The Plan is available to assist personnel in dealing with an unexpected discharge of oil. Its primary purpose is to set in motion the necessary actions to stop or minimize the discharge and to mitigate its effects. Effective planning ensures that the necessary actions are taken in a structured, logical and timely manner.

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the necessary actions to stop or minimize the discharge and to mitigate its effects. Effective planning ensures that the necessary actions are taken in a structured, logical and timely manner.
1.4.1 The Plan must go beyond providing for operational spills. It must include guidance to assist the master in meeting the demands of a catastrophic discharge, should the ship become involved in one.
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1.4.2 The need for a predetermined and properly structured Plan is clear when one considers the pressures and multiple tasks facing personnel confronted with an emergency situation. In the heat of the moment, lack of planning will often result in confusion, mistakes, and failure to advise key people. Delays will be incurred and time will be wasted; time during which the situation may well worsen. As a consequence, the ship and its personnel may be exposed to increasing hazards and greater environmental damage may occur.
1.4.3 For the Plan to accomplish its purpose, it must be:

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well worsen. As a consequence, the ship and its personnel may be exposed to increasing hazards and greater environmental damage may occur.
1.4.3 For the Plan to accomplish its purpose, it must be:
.1 realistic, practical, and easy to use;
.2 understood by ship management personnel, both on board and ashore;
.3 evaluated, reviewed, and updated regularly.
1.4.4 The Plan envisioned by regulation 26 of Annex I to the Convention is intended to be a simple document. Use of summarizing flowcharts or checklists to guide the master through the various actions and decisions required during an incident response is highly encouraged. These can provide a quickly visible and logically sequenced form of information which can reduce error and oversight during emergency situations. Inclusion of extensive background information on the ship, cargo, etc., should be avoided as this is generally

available elsewhere. If such information be relevant, it should be kept to annexes where it will not dilute the ability of ship's personnel to locate operative parts of the Plan.

1.4.5 An example of a summarizing flowchart referred to in paragraph 1.4.4

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annexes where it will not dilute the ability of ship's personnel to locate operative parts of the Plan.

1.4.5 An example of a summarizing flowchart referred to in paragraph 1.4.4 is included in the Example Format for Shipboard Oil Pollution Emergency Plan at appendix II.

1.4.6 The Plan is likely to be a document used on board by the master and officers of the ship. It must therefore be available in the working language of the master and officers. A change in the master and officers which brings about an attendant change in their working language would require the issue of the Plan in the new language.

2 MANDATORY PROVISIONS OF REGULATION 26 OF ANNEX I TO THE CONVENTION

2.1 This section provides individual guidelines for each of the four mandatory provisions of regulation 26 of Annex I to the Convention.

2.2 Regulation 26 of Annex I to the Convention provides that the Plan shall consist at least of: